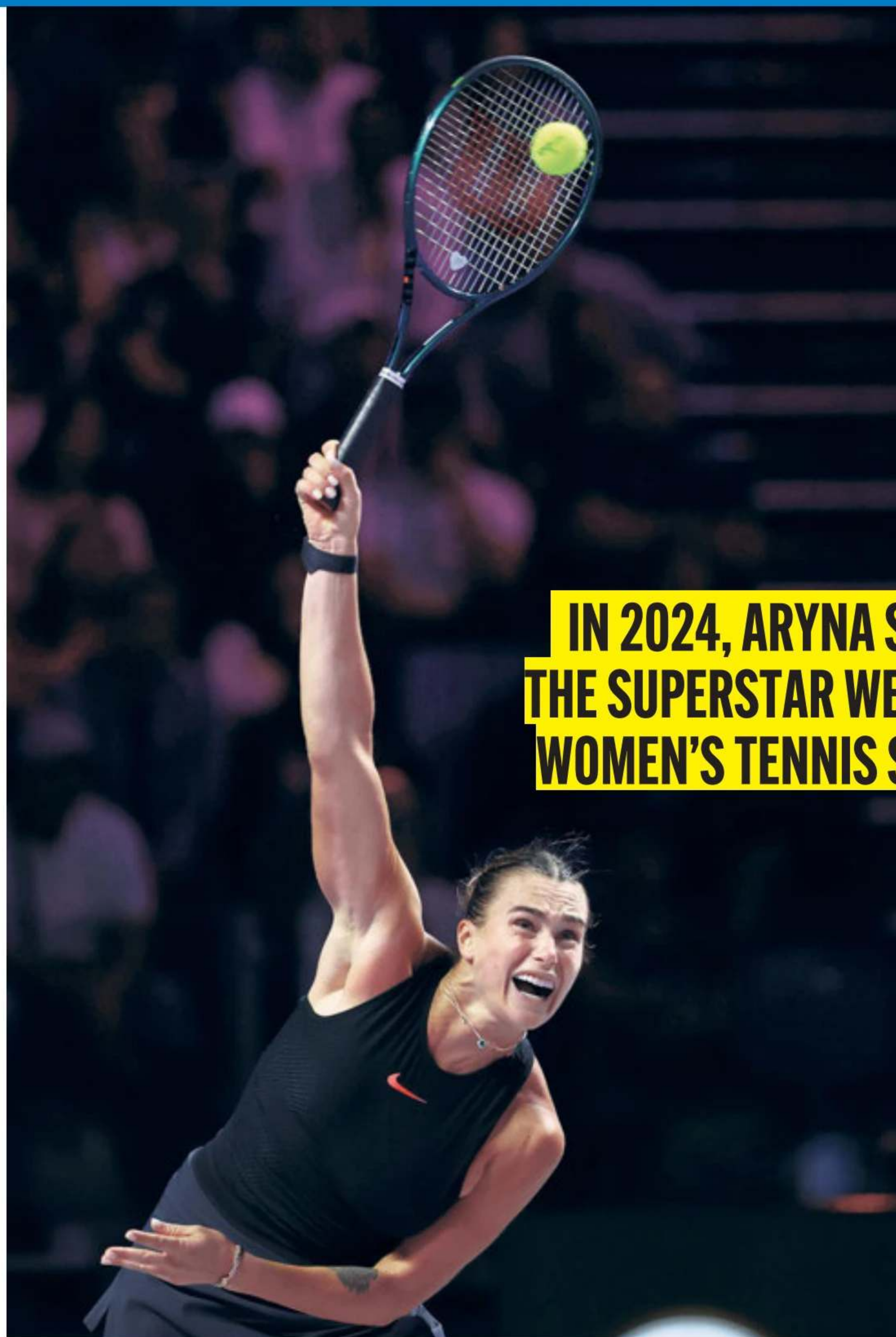




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IN 2024, ARYNA SABALENKA LOOKED LIKE THE SUPERSTAR WE'D BEEN WAITING FOR IN WOMEN'S TENNIS SINCE SERENA WILLIAMS

worthy successor in defending champion Alcaraz. As Djokovic said during the fortnight, "History is on the line."

On June 5, Djokovic underwent surgery to repair a torn meniscus suffered at the French Open and wasn't sure he'd participate in Wimbledon until four days before the start of the revered tournament he'd captured seven times.

Alcaraz whacked winners from every conceivable angle in the first two sets and then weathered a mini comeback in the third set by Djokovic to notch a 6-2, 6-2, 7-6(4) victory in what the Spaniard rated as "probably the best match of my career."

ESPN analyst John McEnroe said, "The mental strength after he blew the 40-love lead [three championship points serving at 5-4] is one of the many reasons we love this guy."

Another reason is the graciousness Alcaraz shows towards his opponents. "I'm still believing that Novak is Superman because of what he has done in this tournament with surgery just a few weeks before the tournament began. It is amazing."

Djokovic hadn't exactly been Superman in 2024, failing to win a tournament going into the Paris Olympics. People wondered whether he could somehow use his Wimbledon momentum to capture

the only prestigious title missing from his incomparable résumé?

In a nostalgic, throwback match, Novak defeated Nadal 6-1, 6-4 in the second round and outclassed Stefanos Tsitsipas 6-3, 7-6(3) and Lorenzo Musetti 6-4, 6-2 to reach the final. Then he avenged his Wimbledon loss by edging Alcaraz

7-6(3), 7-6(2) in the greatest straight-sets men's match in history.

At the US Open, both Alcaraz and Djokovic faltered. Carlos succumbed 6-1, 7-5, 6-4 to 74th-ranked Botic van de Zandschulp, a Dutchman who had contemplated retiring at the end of the year due to a lack of motivation. "You talk about a shocker," said John McEnroe. "It has to be at the top of the all-time shockers." Meanwhile, the 28th-seeded Alexei Popyrin, a late-blooming Aussie with a big serve and potent forehand, upset a sluggish Djokovic 6-4, 6-4, 2-6, 6-4 with 50 winners to reach the fourth round at a Major for the first time. Of far greater historical significance, it marked the first time since 2002 that none of the legendary Big Three won a Major.

Instead, Sinner ensured that the remaining half of the new Big Two reigned supreme. The 23-year-old Italian eliminated a quartet of Americans, plus No. 5 Daniil Medvedev — who had beaten Sinner at Wimbledon — and fast-rising Englishman Jack Draper.

Taylor Fritz defeated No. 8 Casper Ruud 3-6, 6-4, 6-3, 6-2 and No. 4 Alexander Zverev 7-6(2), 3-6, 6-4, 7-6(3) to reach his first Grand Slam